



SPORTS

GAZING

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CLEARWATER, FLA, MARCH 21. — WHAT MEASURE of success will the Phillies achieve in the upcoming National League pennant race with new, youthful athletes taking over for the once heralded Whiz Kids?

This question undoubtedly creates more discussion than any other concerning major league clubs training in this area. Lightly regarded by the experts when the club started falling apart the new cast at least is being looked upon with some consideration.

The hitting potential is fair to good, the pitching could be sensational, but the enthusiasm, drive and spirited effort is remindful of the 1950 club that chugged along to Philadelphia's first National League pennant in 35 years.

This piece is not intended to mean that we think this club can win a pennant, or even finish as high as seventh place. For the most part the 1960 Phillies will be a band of untried and untested performers. Except for veteran pitchers like Robin Roberts and Curt Simmons—the only members of the Whiz Kids gang who still remain—and some old hands like Wally Post, Alvin Dark and Dave Philley, they will range in age from 18 to 26.

However, this season the Phillies will once again be trying for the big play . . . the long hit . . . the throw from right field to third base or from center field to the plate. These items were almost a lost art on the Phillies clubs of the past two or three seasons.

But there will be mistakes. Overthrows and wild throws will not be uncommon until the team begins to jell and calm prevails among a jittery cast. There will be interesting action, however, and this latest youth movement will, in time, win back most of the Phillies' huge following.

From now on when you read about the Phillies the articles will be concerned with such performers as catchers Jim Coker and Clayt Dalrymple; infielders Pancho Herrera, Bob Malkmus, Jim Woods or Ted Lepcio; outfielders Johnny Callison and Ken Walters together with a sprinkling of some of the holdover youngsters who have been with the club the past two or three seasons.

Here's some of the credentials of the players mentioned above. Coker, who played at Buffalo last year, was one of the outstanding catchers in the International League. He caught 111 games, compiled a .290 batting average, knocked in 64 runs, and accounted for 22 doubles, three triples and 15 home runs. At the moment, he's slated to be the No. 1 catcher. Dalrymple, a 23-year-old 6-footer from Chico, Calif., is graduating from the Sacramento club of the Pacific Coast League where he batted .230.

Malkmus saw action at Denver, Woods played with Lancaster, and Herrera who has tried to make the grade with the Phils in previous years, is finally expected to succeed. Playing at Buffalo last season, Frank was the most outstanding performer in the International League. He rapped the ball for a .327 mark, batted in 129 runs and pumped 37 home runs out of the field.

And as of now, the Phillies are giving Herrera an earnest shot at converting into a second baseman. Normally a first sacker, Herrera has at time operated at third. But the switch to second is something entirely new for the 6-3, 220-pound Cuban. He has accepted the challenge, however. The Phillies are pleased with his attitude, and the club could open the season with the tallest and heaviest second baseman in the Majors.

Andy Cohen, the one-time New York Giants second baseman during the John McGraw regime, and now a Phillies coach, is one of Herrera's best rooters. "This boy has improved tremendously," Andy says. "Naturally, he has still a lot to learn about playing second base. But I have never seen anyone catch on so fast. His biggest problem is weight . . . he will have to take off quite a bit in order to improve his speed. He's a little late in coming in on slow hit balls, but I think he has a wonderful chance."